



Christopher Armstrong

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<https://opstrong.com>

Strategic, people-first leader of high-performing technical teams. Proven success recruiting talent and leading healthy and efficient organizations that deliver highly-technical products. Leads with empathy and vulnerability, with a focus on healthy organizational culture and happy, productive teams.

Technical expertise in cloud-native technologies and practices, including DevOps, DevTools, and Site Reliability Engineering. Special interest in building remote-first company culture for high-performing distributed teams, particularly for Site Reliability Engineering and Production Engineering teams.

WHERE I SHINE

People-First Culture

Build culture of empathy and vulnerability, and foster flourishing through mentoring, coaching, and leveling-up of employees

Dynamic Organizations

Proactively define roles and identify, recruit, onboard, and mentor talent to execute on evolving objectives

User-Centric Focus

Champion stakeholder requirements and user experience throughout design and development process

Cloud Native

Substantial technical depth with modern cloud infrastructure, DevOps, and Site Reliability Engineering practices

FUNCTIONAL COMPETENCIES / EXPERTISE

Engineering Team Leadership | Strategic Planning | Budgeting & Resource Allocation | Product Roadmap Development
Agile/Scrum Process & SDLC Management | Open Source Software & Community Development | Linux Containers (Docker)
Cluster Software and Schedulers (Kubernetes) | Microservice Architecture | Distributed Systems & Software
Cloud Infrastructure (AWS, Azure, Google Cloud) | DevOps & DevTools | Scalable Infrastructure & Deployment Automation
(Vagrant, Terraform) | Community Evangelism & Public Speaking

EMPLOYMENT HISTORY & ACCOMPLISHMENTS

CAREER BREAK—*Yearlong sabbatical to rest, recharge, and intentionally consider my next role*

Feb 2022 – Present

HASHICORP—*Strategic technical leadership position at this fast-growing, industry-leading infrastructure company*

Director, Platform Engineering

Remote: Feb 2020 – Feb 2022

Responded to identified organizational challenges by proposing and establishing a new engineering group responsible for platform reliability, including teams focused on: infrastructure (Site Reliability Engineers maintaining Terraform Cloud infrastructure and data stores), core services (software engineers architecting foundational services written in Go), and enablement (DevTools, test infrastructure, developer productivity)

- Established an organizational charter, and aligned teams around a shared identity and common purpose within the engineering organization
- Fostered a culture of operational maturity, service ownership, and reliability across peer engineering teams, and established an on-call rotation for senior platform engineers
- Defined directional strategy and roadmap leading to several significant improvements to systems infrastructure and platform architecture
- Proposed and led sweeping culture initiatives affecting engineering more broadly, including a career matrix refresh affecting all engineers

- Served as a standards-bearer for HashiCorp by performing interviews for both engineers and engineering managers across our organization
- Led from a place of empathy and vulnerability amidst challenging circumstances during COVID-19

OPSTRONG TECHNICAL PARTNERS—*Technical strategy consulting and leadership coaching for growth startups*

Founder and Principal

Seattle, WA: Apr 2016 – Present

Started a coaching and consulting practice (<https://opstrong.com/>) to coach, mentor, and advise entrepreneurs and technical executives to help them build healthy cultures and productive teams. In addition to coaching many leaders, I have also served as an adviser or interim technical executive for several fast-growing local companies:

- CTO at LogixBoard, a SaaS startup focused on disrupting the \$2T freight forwarding industry—recruited the initial technical team and defined technical and product strategy to ensure rapid build and deployment of the highly-scalable platform
- Director of Product at Xinova, a company focused on disrupting innovation—advised engineering leadership to identify gaps in accountability and delivery, and helped interview and hire new leadership
- Director of Engineering at Algorithmia, an enterprise data science PaaS startup—designed the technical organization, recruited talent, and created a culture fostering scalable work processes, better defined responsibilities, and happier employees
- Strategic Adviser for Zingo Credit, a web platform enabling consumers to report additional factors (rental history, utilities, etc.) to credit bureaus to improve their credit scores—helped craft technical and product strategy and mentor and coach leadership
- Strategic Adviser for Ganaz, a SaaS and mobile startup focused on improving the experience of migrant laborers—helped non-technical founders recruit and hire their first CTO
- Mentored founders at Techstars Seattle and Startup Hall at University of Washington

DEIS—*Open-source DevOps Platform-as-a-Service (PaaS) organization focused on making apps easier to deploy and manage*

Vice President, Engineering

Remote: Mar 2014 – Apr 2016

Grew the Deis engineering organization from two to twenty-five engineers, including a merger with Engine Yard, a San Francisco-based company. Oversaw the development of Deis, an open-source PaaS, and Helm, the Kubernetes package manager. Deis was acquired by Engine Yard in April 2015 and then again by Microsoft in April 2017, joining Azure Kubernetes Service.

- Reported to CEO and held accountability to the Board of Directors for delivery of multiple products
- Drove the entire software development cycle from start to finish, addressing roadblocks and facilitating creative problem-solving discussions among internal team members to ensure releases are shipped on-time
- Crafted departmental culture and organizational structure as a manager-of-managers, setting departmental priorities and ensuring contributors and leaders are growing in their role
- Played lead role in establishing and growing a vibrant open-source development community around the products, resulting in contributions from 150+ community members, and coordinating development through innovative open product roadmap sessions
- Led recruiting efforts to identify and attract technical talent to the organization, including highly-skilled specialized engineers in Linux system software, developer tooling, and distributed systems architecture
- Provided training to the company's sales and support teams around the Deis platform, ensuring they're armed with the latest knowledge regarding the offering and understand its unique positioning within the IT ecosystem
- Evangelized the Deis platform at conferences, meetups, and hackathons, in addition to spearheading initiatives with the technology's vibrant open source community to boost awareness and adoption

SOCRATA—*Innovative Seattle analytics startup, focused on finding new ways to leverage government data for social good*

Site Reliability Engineer

Seattle, WA: Feb 2013 – Jan 2014

Infrastructure engineer focused on scalable infrastructure and on building processes and team culture fostering transparency and employee happiness

- Designed and built tooling and infrastructure to foster the engineering team's productivity and processes

- Fostered a healthy culture company-wide, authoring a “culture manifesto” with recommendations for sweeping improvements to company policy
- Defined and implemented a culture component for technical interview loops, and served as the first culture representative for interviews

JAZZHR—*Developer of groundbreaking recruiting software / applicant tracking system (ATS)*

Director of Engineering

Pittsburgh, PA: Sept 2010 – Dec 2012

Joined as the first hire and led all product development efforts; recruited and led a lean, productive engineering organization.

- Worked closely with the founder/CEO and senior leadership team of the organization to understand the company’s objective, and defined a product roadmap that
- Led recruiting efforts to grow the engineering team from 2 to 9 members during tenure, onboarding staff and providing hands-on mentoring to maximize team performance and the professional growth of individual contributors
- Oversaw all feature design, development, and implementation related to the product, advocating for users and stakeholder value
- Represented the engineering team’s interests to company leadership, advocating for cultural changes and the creation of new professional growth opportunities in order to combat turnover, stagnation, and inefficiency
- Managed budget and led numerous initiatives, upgrades, and architecture changes in order to accommodate the rapid growth of the platform to encompass thousands of active customer accounts
- Participated in local developer meetups/hackathons in order to evangelize the company’s product and support ongoing recruiting efforts focused on developers, testers, and data scientists

EDUCATION & ADDITIONAL INTERESTS

Research Fellow | Trinity Fellows Academy, Washington, DC metro area

Awarded a scholarship to study applied philosophy, theology, and cultural critique

Completed a thesis exploring how the tech industry can better serve people, entitled “Startups, Love Thy Neighbor”

B.S., Computer Science & Economics | University of Pittsburgh, Pittsburgh, PA

Focus on system architecture and software engineering; also devised and conducted behavioral economics research

Coach—ongoing coaching engagements with technical leaders of quickly-growing companies (topics of organizational design, recruiting & retention strategy, mentorship of team, etc.)

Mentor—Techstars Seattle, [Fledge](#) (the “conscious company” accelerator), and [Jolkona](#) (social entrepreneurship program)

Outside interests—aviation (flight instructor-in-training), organizational psychology, and counseling therapy